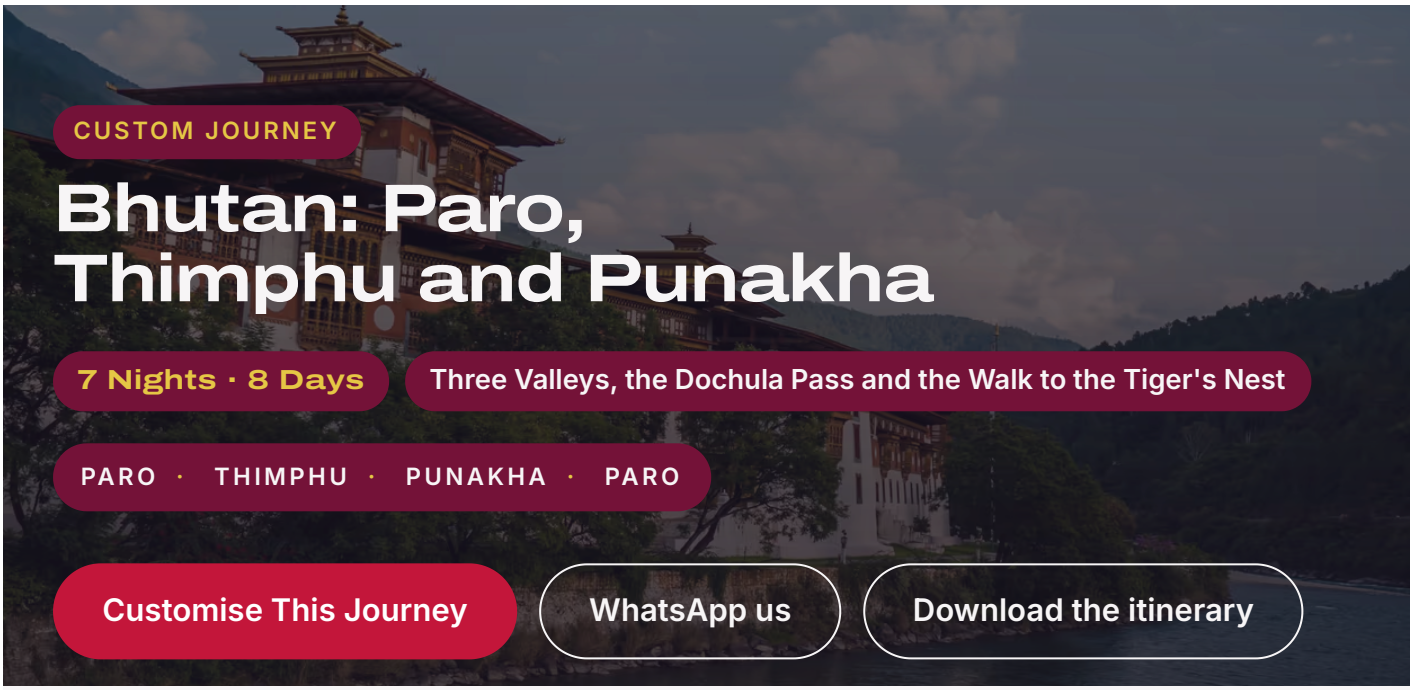
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CUSTOM JOURNEY

Bhutan: Paro, Thimphu and Punakha

7 Nights · 8 Days

Three Valleys, the Dochula Pass and the Walk to the Tiger's Nest

PARO · THIMPHU · PUNAKHA · PARO

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DURATION
7 Nights · 8 Days

ROUTE
Paro return

PACE
Relaxed

BEST SEASON
March to May and September to November

IDEAL FOR
Couples, Families, Seniors

Bhutan controls tourism deliberately, and the effect is a country that has stayed itself. This week takes the three valleys that make a first visit (Paro, the capital at Thimphu, and Punakha across the Dochula Pass) at a pace the country sets rather than the itinerary: a dzong a day, a market, an archery ground, a temple reached through rice fields, and the walk up to the Tiger's Nest saved for the last full morning, when you are ready for it.

It is written for travellers from India, who need a permit rather than a visa and pay a daily fee at a different rate, and it works by air into Paro or by road from the Bengal border. Both are set out below. Every transfer, guide and permit is arranged.

Journey Highlights

- **Land** at Paro on one of the most scenic approaches in the world, weaving between Himalayan peaks into the valley, or drive up from the border through changing country.
- **See** Rinpung Dzong, the fortress-monastery above Paro, and the National Museum in the old watchtower on the hill behind it.
- **Stand** beneath the Buddha Dordenma above Thimphu, and at Tashichho Dzong, seat of Bhutan's government and its clergy.
- **Eat** ema datshi and red rice at a Thimphu table, visit the market, and watch archery (the national sport) at the traditional ground.
- **Cross** the Dochula Pass, with its 108 chortens against the high peaks when the weather allows, and descend to Punakha's warm valley.
- **Walk** through farmland to Chimi Lhakhang, and stand at Punakha Dzong, arguably the most beautiful in the country, where two rivers meet.
- **Climb** to Taktsang, the Tiger's Nest, clinging to its cliff nine hundred metres above the Paro valley, given a whole, unhurried morning.

Itinerary at a Glance

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 01	Paro	Arrival by air or road; a walk in the valley
Day 02	Paro	Rinpung Dzong and the National Museum

DAY	DESTINATION	SIGNATURE EXPERIENCE
Day 03	**Paro to Thimphu**	Buddha Dordenma and Tashichho Dzong
Day 04	**Thimphu**	The market, a Bhutanese lunch, archery
Day 05	**Thimphu to Punakha**	Over the Dochula Pass; Punakha Dzong
Day 06	**Punakha**	A farmland walk to Chimi Lhakhang
Day 07	**Punakha to Paro**	The hike to the Tiger's Nest
Day 08	**Departure**	Fly out of Paro, or drive down to the border

Day by Day

Expand all

Day 01 Paro: Arrival in the Valley

Flight · Fly to Paro, or by road via Phuntsholing

By air, fly directly into Paro on one of the world's most scenic approaches, weaving between Himalayan peaks before touching down in the valley. By road, enter through Phuntsholing on the West Bengal border and drive up, a full day's journey through changing landscapes. Settle in and take a gentle walk around Paro town, framed by pine-covered hills.

Overnight in Paro

Day 02 Paro: The Dzong and the Watchtower

A relaxed day in the valley, getting acquainted with Bhutanese architecture and everyday life before the big hike later in the trip. Rinpung Dzong, the fortress-monastery overlooking the valley, and the National Museum, housed in the old round watchtower above it. In the evening, a stroll along the Paro River.

Overnight in Paro

Day 03 Thimphu: A Capital Without Traffic Lights

Drive · about 1½ hours

A short, scenic drive to Thimphu, one of the few capital cities in the world without a single traffic light. The towering Buddha Dordenma statue overlooking the valley, and Tashichho Dzong, seat of Bhutan's government and clergy. The evening is at leisure in the town.

Overnight in Thimphu

Day 04 Thimphu: Markets, Lunch and Archery

A slower day exploring the capital's living culture, from its markets to its craft traditions. A visit to the local market and a traditional Bhutanese lunch of ema datshi (chillies in cheese) and red rice. Optionally, the Folk Heritage Museum, or the traditional archery ground, where the national sport is played with more noise and ceremony than you would expect.

Overnight in Thimphu

Day 05 Punakha: Over the Dochula Pass

Drive · about 3 hours over the Dochula Pass

Over the dramatic Dochula Pass, one of Bhutan's most photographed spots (108 chortens set against the Himalayan peaks, weather permitting), and down into Punakha's subtropical valley. Punakha Dzong, arguably the most beautiful fortress in the country, stands where two rivers meet.

Overnight in Punakha

Day 06 Punakha: Rice Fields and the Divine Madman

On foot · A short walk through farmland

A gentle valley day surrounded by rice fields and river views. A short walk through farmland to Chimi Lhakhang, the fertility temple founded by the Divine Madman, Drukpa Kunley, whose irreverence is still painted on the village walls.

Overnight in Punakha

Day 07 Paro: The Tiger's Nest

Hike · Taktsang monastery, a full morning

Return to Paro for the trip's signature experience, kept unhurried and given a full morning: the hike to Taktsang Monastery, the Tiger's Nest, clinging to a cliff face nine hundred metres above the valley floor. It comes at the end of the week on purpose, once you are used to the altitude and the walking.

Overnight in Paro

Day 08 Paro: Departure

By air, fly out from Paro with one last look at the Himalaya from above. By road, drive back down to Phuntsholing and cross the border.

Departure

Practical notes

Entry

Indian nationals do not need a visa: a valid passport or voter ID and an entry permit, arranged online in advance or on arrival. Other nationalities need a visa; ask us when booking.

The daily fee

Bhutan's Sustainable Development Fee applies per night for Indian nationals, at a different rate from other visitors. We confirm the current rate before you book and include it in the quotation.

Getting there

Direct flights to Paro from Kolkata and Guwahati take about ninety minutes. By road, Phuntsholing is five to six hours from Bagdogra or Guwahati, then another five to six up to Thimphu or Paro.

Best time to visit

March to May and September to November for clear mountain views. Winter is cold and bright; the monsoon months hide the peaks.

Pace

Relaxed. One long drive day over the Dochula Pass and one hike, with the rest unhurried. The Ngultrum is pegged to the rupee and INR is widely accepted.